among some of the Sikhs to adopt Hindu religious practices, such as idol worship, pilgrimage to religious places and observation of Brahminical rituals. He would object to Sikhs cutting their hair or trimming their beards, drinking alcohol and smoking. But Sanjay Gandhi and Zail Singh were not concerned with his dharam prachar (religious preaching). He had to be groomed to take up political causes that would appeal to the Sikh masses and embarrass the moderate Akali Dal leadership, thereby building pressure on them to either adopt a harder line or lose their Sikh following.

An opportunity to test Bhindranwale's political mettle presented itself on 13 April 1978, when the Akali Dal government in Punjab allowed the Nirankari sect to hold its convention in Amritsar. This was done to please a group of Hindu traders in Amritsar who were supporters of the Janata Party, a coalition partner in the state's Akali Dal government. A large congregation of Sikhs present at the Golden Temple on the occasion of Baisakhi protested, since the Sikhs consider the Nirankaris to be heretics.

Addressing the gathering, Bhindranwale strongly objected to the Nirankari convention in Amritsar and exhorted the audience to march to the convention site and disrupt it. Fauja Singh, an agriculture inspector in the Punjab government, led the Sikh procession, shouting slogans against the Nirankaris. On reaching the site of the convention, Fauja Singh drew his sword and tried to kill the sect's head, Gurbachan Singh. But before he could do so Gurbachan Singh's bodyguards shot Fauja Singh dead. In the battle that followed, thirteen Sikhs and three Nirankaris lost their lives. [3]

The Sikhs who were killed became martyrs, and 1 Akbar Road had a cause for which Bhindranwale could be encouraged to fight. The state government prosecuted sixty-four Nirankaris, including its head, Gurbachan Singh, in the case. But the trial was shifted to the sessions court in Karnal in Haryana, and the accused were acquitted in 1980. Following the Nirankari convention incident, Bhindranwale became extremely critical of the Akali Dal leadership. Soon after the incident he attended an Akali Dal conference at Ludhiana, where he criticized a senior Akali Dal leader (Jathedar Jagdev Singh Talwandi) in his presence but without naming him.